Daily Content Intel

August 13, 2026

Topic A — Reel

TELEPROMPTER COPY (paste into Instagram)

Okay, there's a study out in the European Journal of Sport Science looking at how athletes actually stop, and I think it's the most useful thing I've read this month.

They took 19 multidirectional team sport athletes, ran them at 100, 85, and 70 percent of max sprint speed, told them to shut it down, and then measured the force in each individual braking step.

Here's what came out. The athletes who decelerated best on that first step were the ones putting the most horizontal force into the ground. By step 3 what mattered most was how that force was aimed. The correlations were strong, 0.56 to 0.95.

So step 1 is a magnitude problem, and step 3 is a direction problem.

What that means for a football or a lacrosse kid on Monday: you train the brake on purpose. Sink the hips and the knees on that first contact so the athlete can actually absorb the load, and then coach the landing position on the next two steps, foot in front of the body, shin angled back, chest stacked over the hips.

That's the cut. That's also the knee you're protecting.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Hook: Every cut on the field starts with a brake, and the brake is the part your program skips.

Spoken script (word for word):

Okay, there's a study out in the European Journal of Sport Science looking at how athletes actually stop, and I think it's the most useful thing I've read this month.

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On-screen text seeds:

- 0:00 EVERY CUT STARTS WITH A BRAKE
- 0:06 19 athletes. 100%, 85%, 70% of max sprint. Then stop.
- 0:20 STEP 1: how much force
- 0:27 STEP 3: where the force is aimed
- 0:34 r = 0.56 to 0.95
- 0:45 Monday: coach the first contact
- 0:58 Foot in front. Shin back. Chest stacked.
- 1:12 Braking is a trainable skill

Caption (copy-paste ready):

Every cut starts with a brake.

New work in the European Journal of Sport Science put athletes at 100, 85, and 70 percent of max sprint speed and measured the force in each braking step. Step 1 was about how much horizontal force they could put into the ground. Step 3 was about how that force was aimed.

Two different problems, two different coaching cues.

Most high school programs spend the whole offseason on acceleration and give braking about 4 minutes at the end of a warmup. Then week 6 shows up and the change of direction looks ugly.

Train the brake. Sink the hips and knees on first contact, then clean up the landing position on the next two steps.

I help athletes and active adults get back to playing at their highest level.
threshold.clientsecure.me

Dr. Lars Stevenson, PT, DPT

#footballtraining #lacrosse #speedtraining #changeofdirection #aclprevention #strengthandconditioning #youthathlete #sportsphysicaltherapy #returntosport #athletedevelopment

Personalize this

- Which of your football or lacrosse athletes actually decelerates well right now, and what does his first braking step look like on video compared to the kid who keeps rolling an ankle on cuts?
- You program change of direction in the offseason blocks. What's your current progression for teaching the landing position (foot placement, shin angle, hip height), and where does it sit in the session?
- On the return-to-sport side, where does braking quality show up in your clearance decisions? Name a specific athlete where the deceleration looked wrong and you held him back an extra block.
- How does this map to the CROSS framework, and which letter does "can you stop" live under when you explain it to a parent?

Screenshots:

- title | https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC13408429/ | "Early Horizontal Deceleration Ability Across Multiple Steps and Approach Speeds in Multidirectional

Team Sport Athletes"

- physiology | https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC13408429/ | "Greater within-step deceleration significantly correlated with greater mean horizontal GRF and H-V force ratio across all steps and approach speeds"
- actionable | https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC13408429/ | "Practitioners should target the attenuation of horizontal force magnitude in step 1 via greater peak hip and knee flexion"

Sources:

- https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC13408429/
- https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/42516018/

Topic B — Reel

TELEPROMPTER COPY (paste into Instagram)

Okay, hot take. If you're giving your athletes 4 sets of 9 Nordic curls twice a week in season, you're buying a lot of soreness for very little return.

There's a study in Frontiers in Sports and Active Living. 60 youth soccer players, 8 weeks, in season, twice a week. Three groups. One did 4 sets of 3. One did 4 sets of 6. One did 4 sets of 9. Same exercise, same schedule, the only thing that changed was volume.

The group doing 4 sets of 3 improved change of direction more than both of the other groups, with the ball and without it, and the biggest gap was against the high volume group. The 10 meter sprint went the same direction.

I've been saying this to coaches for a while and it's kind of unpopular. The

Nordic is a heavy, high tension eccentric. It's a stimulus, and a lot of programs prescribe it like it's conditioning.

12 hard reps a session, in season, is plenty. Take the other 24 reps and go sprint.

Fair hedge: this is one 8 week block in male youth soccer players, so I wouldn't call it settled. But the direction is pretty clear, and it matches what I see in the weight room.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Hook: 4 sets of 9 Nordics is making your athletes worse at cutting.

Spoken script (word for word):

Okay, hot take. If you're giving your athletes 4 sets of 9 Nordic curls twice a week in season, you're buying a lot of soreness for very little return.

There's a study in Frontiers in Sports and Active Living. 60 youth soccer players, 8 weeks, in season, twice a week. Three groups. One did 4 sets of 3. One did 4 sets of 6. One did 4 sets of 9. Same exercise, same schedule, the only thing that changed was volume.

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12 hard reps a session, in season, is plenty. Take the other 24 reps and go sprint.

Fair hedge: this is one 8 week block in male youth soccer players, so I wouldn't call it settled. But the direction is pretty clear, and it matches what I see in the weight room.

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On-screen text seeds:

- 0:00 12 REPS BEAT 36
- 0:08 60 players. 8 weeks. In season. 2x/week.
- 0:18 4x3 vs 4x6 vs 4x9
- 0:30 4x3 won change of direction
- 0:38 Biggest gap: 4x3 vs 4x9
- 0:50 12 hard reps is plenty
- 1:02 Spend the other 24 on sprinting
- 1:15 TREAT IT AS A STIMULUS

Caption (copy-paste ready):

Your athletes do not need 36 Nordic curls a session.

60 youth soccer players, 8 weeks, in season, twice a week. One group did 4 sets of 3, one did 4 sets of 6, one did 4 sets of 9. Only the volume changed.

The 4 sets of 3 group improved change of direction more than both other groups, and the largest gap was against the highest volume group. The 10 meter sprint followed the same pattern.

The Nordic is a heavy eccentric stimulus. In season, 12 quality reps gets the job done, and the leftover time is better spent sprinting.

One 8 week block in male youth soccer, so hold it loosely. The direction still matches what I see with my athletes.

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threshold.clientsecure.me

Dr. Lars Stevenson, PT, DPT

#nordiccurl #hamstring #hamstringinjury #inseasontraining #footballtraining #lacrosse #strengthandconditioning #youthathlete #speedtraining #sportsphysicaltherapy

Personalize this

- What's your actual in-season Nordic prescription for your high school football athletes right now, and how did you land on that number?
- Name a hamstring case where high Nordic volume backfired (soreness into a game week, or an athlete who stopped

doing them because they hurt). That's the story that sells this one.

- You program sprinting as the primary hamstring protector. How do you sequence Nordics against sprint exposure inside a football or lacrosse week, and what do you cut first when the schedule gets tight?
- How do you explain "the Nordic is a stimulus" to a head coach who measures effort by how sore the kids are the next day?

Screenshots:

- title | https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC13378016/ | "Low-volume Nordic hamstring training improves change-of-direction performance more than higher volumes in youth soccer players"
- physiology | https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC13378016/ | "interaction was observed for the CoD without (p=0.002) and with the ball (CoDB, p=0.014)"
- actionable | https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC13378016/ | "Low-volume

Nordic curl training is the most effective training dose for improving CoD performance in top-tier youth soccer athletes."

Sources:

- https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC13378016/
- https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/42491631/

Reference

Runner-up topics

- Serial ACL-RSI scores predict reinjury type in adolescents: low scores flag graft failure risk, rapidly rising high scores flag contralateral injury risk (McAleese et al, OJSM 2026, PMID 42137418). Excellent psychological-readiness angle, SAGE blocks automated fetch so screenshots need a workaround.
- Sprint speed adaptations in elite soccer: 20 m speed improved 0.90% vs 0.52% at 10 m, a 75% larger gain over the longer distance (Loturco et al, JSCR, Aug 11 2026, PMID 42579440). Good "stop testing only the 10" angle.
- Low-volume, high-velocity training and realistic expectations for sprint gains in team sport, pulled from the same JSCR practical application.

Sources scanned today

- Newsletter digest newsletter_digest_2026-08-12.pdf: 1 source (Dr. Mercola promo email, plastics/NAC/krill oil ad copy). No usable clinical finding, skipped.

- PubMed, last 7-30 days, filtered to football / lacrosse / team-sport athlete performance, sprint, return-to-sport, recovery. 30 recent titles reviewed.
- European Journal of Sport Science: early horizontal deceleration across braking steps (Aug 2026). **Selected, Draft A.**
- Frontiers in Sports and Active Living: Nordic curl volume dose-response in youth soccer (Jul 2026). **Selected, Draft B.**
- Journal of Strength and Conditioning Research: sprint speed adaptations in elite soccer, 10 m vs 20 m (Aug 11 2026). Strong runner-up.
- Orthopaedic Journal of Sports Medicine: serial ACL-RSI scores predict reinjury type in adolescents (McAleese et al). Strong runner-up. SAGE full text returns 403 to automated fetch, so screenshots would fall back to cards.
- BJSM / JOSPT / Sports Health, NSCA blog, Examine, Pacey Performance and

Just Fly show notes, r/AdvancedFitness week: scanned, nothing fresher that beat the two picks.

- Cold-water-immersion adaptation-blunting search: literature is all pre-2026, no new signal this week.